

STUDENT ATTENDANCE REQUIREMENTS AND PROCEDURES

This policy addresses student attendance requirements and school attendance procedures. Each parent/guardian or person having control or charge of a child within the compulsory attendance age is responsible for their child's regular and punctual attendance at school as required under provisions of the law. Student attendance is a cooperative effort and the School Board involves parents/guardians and students in accepting the responsibility for excellent attendance.

Any request for exemption from compulsory attendance shall be presented annually in writing to the Superintendent or designee per LCPS Policy 8120 (Compulsory Attendance).

A. Procedures.

1. Notification of Absence. Parents/guardians of students who are absent should inform the school of the reason for the absence on the morning of the absence. If the parent/guardian has not previously contacted the school regarding the absence, the parent/guardian must notify the school of the reason for the absence no later than the date the student returns to school.

2. Observance of a Religious Holiday. School absences for the purpose of participating in these observances will be excused. Student shall not be deprived of an award, or eligibility or opportunity to complete for any award, or the right to make up any missed work and complete any missed assessments. Parent/guardian must provide written verification to the principal or designee.

3. Automatic Withdrawal from Enrollment. If a student is absent for 15 consecutive school days or more, they will automatically be withdrawn from LCPS, in accordance with [8 VAC 20-110-130](#) and will be required to re-enroll as an LCPS student.

B. Definitions.

1. Absence. Absence from school for any period of time will result in loss of learning. It is important for each student to be present whenever possible to take full advantage of the educational opportunities offered by the school.

- a. Excused absences. Students should attend school for the full day unless excused per this policy. There are circumstances that may prevent a student's attendance in school. Such absences, when justifiable, are classified as excused absences for which there are no consequences; however, the principal or designee may request that proper documentation or an appropriate explanation be furnished.

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Reasons for excused absences include:

- (i) personal illness or injury (including mental health and substance abuse illnesses);
- (ii) death in the family;
- (iii) medical or dental appointments or procedures;
- (iv) school suspensions;
- (v) court appearances or other legal obligations; and
- (vi) military obligations.

In addition, principals may excuse students who are absent for any of the following reasons:

- (i) illness in the immediate family that requires the student to be absent;
- (ii) emergencies that require the student to be absent;
- (iii) trips or activities that enhance or extend the student's education, when approved by the principal in advance; however, standard family trips and vacations should be scheduled during school holidays and over the summer break and are otherwise deemed to be unexcused absences;
- (iv) middle and high school students, who engage in an optional civic activity/event (not supervised by LCPS staff); however, such excused absence for such purpose is limited to one school day per school year;
- (v) While a student's first time missing a partial or full day of school for participating in a 4-H activity will not be counted as an absence (either excused or unexcused), every subsequent time a student misses a partial or full day of school while participating in a 4-H educational program or activity will be counted as an excused absence. No credit will be provided for a student whose participation in a 4-H educational program or activity occurs during scheduled Standards of Learning assessments or during any period of

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time that the student is suspended or expelled from school
In such instances, the student's principal or assistant principal may request a representative of 4-H to provide documentation of a student's participation in order for the student's absence to be excused; and

- (vi) subject to guidelines established by the Virginia Department of Education, students who are members of a state or federally recognized tribal nation that is headquartered in Virginia may attend such nation's pow wow gathering, provided that the student's parent provides the student's school advance notice of the absence in the manner required by the school; however, such excused absences for such purpose is limited to one school day per school year.

- b. Unexcused absences. An unexcused absence is an absence where a student misses their scheduled instructional school day in its entirety and no indication/notification has been received by school personnel within 5 days of such absence, that the student's parent/guardian is aware of and/or supports the absence, or the parent/guardian provides a reason for the absence that does not fall within the scope of an excused absence as set forth herein, or is otherwise unacceptable to the school administration as provided by Regulation 8140. Examples of unexcused absences, include, but are not limited to, absences due to truancy, missing a ride, a bus, or car troubles, and vacations or family trips.

The school administration, in its discretion, may change an unexcused absence to an excused absence when a parent/guardian provides an acceptable reason for the student's absence per this policy or there are otherwise extenuating circumstances warranting such modification.

- c. Suspension absences. Absences caused by a student's suspension from school are recorded as suspension absences and are marked as excused absences. Principals shall establish procedures to be followed in their schools regarding suspension absences. School administrators will ensure that suspended students are able to access and complete assignments (graded or otherwise) during and after the suspension.

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2. Truancy. Truancy means the act of accruing one or more unexcused absences. Truancy is a serious offense that warrants timely corrective action on the part of the school and the parents/guardians or other adults having control of the student. All cases of truancy shall be reported to parents/guardians.

3. Tardiness. A student is tardy when they arrive at an assigned place after the time their school schedule requires them to be there. Tardiness may be caused by many factors, and teachers and administrators should always determine the reason for tardiness. Tardiness that resulted from valid reasons should be addressed accordingly. Repeated or habitual tardiness, however, encourages the formation of undesirable personal habits and disrupts the orderly instructional process of the school. Therefore, corrective action is required, and the principal and/or teacher should employ appropriate interventions.

4. Make-up work. Whenever a student is absent, whether it is an excused, unexcused, or a suspension absence, make-up work may be required. If the principal requires students to complete make-up work, the student will be afforded a reasonable amount of time, consistent with the length of the absence, to make up the work missed. The student and their teacher are responsible for developing a plan to make-up the work, upon the student's return from their absence. The teacher is responsible for providing assignments, tests, and other work that must be made up by the student and for informing the student, and the parent/guardian, as appropriate, when the work is due. A student's failure to complete such make-up work within the time allowed will impact the final grade for those assignments, tests, or other work. Make-up work turned in within the time allowed will be graded on the same basis as other work, as if timely submitted.

5. Dismissal Precautions. Principals or designees shall not release a student to any person not authorized by the student's parent/guardian to assume responsibility for the student. Students will be released only on request and authorization of the parent/guardian or authorized individuals that are serving as in-loco parentis. A formal checkout procedure is established in each school. The responsibility to prove their authority to obtain the release of a student, to any person not identified as the parent/guardian, is on the person requesting release of the student from school and must meet the satisfaction of school staff.

6. Excellent Attendance Certificates. If a school awards certificates for excellence in attendance, that school must present such a certificate to any child having no unexcused absences and no more than five excused absences, exclusive of any properly verified excused absences for observance of a religious holiday as herein provided, in a regular school term.

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C. Compulsory Attendance.

1. Student attendance will be monitored and reported by LCPS as required by the Virginia Department of Education, state law and applicable regulations. The principal or designee, and unified mental health team members, including but not limited to the school counselor, school social worker, school psychologist, student assistance specialist, family liaison, school nurse, attendance officer will monitor absences, provide support, recommendations, and/or interventions for students that are not complying with

compulsory attendance requirements for students who are not regularly attending school and/or are chronically absent or tardy.

2. Whenever a student fails to report to school on a regularly scheduled school day and no information has been received by school personnel that the parent is aware of and/or supports the absence, the school principal or designee, attendance officer, or other school personnel will notify the parent by phone, email, or other electronic means to obtain an explanation. The school will otherwise record the absence as “excused” or “unexcused” in accordance with this policy.

3. If a student accrues five or more unexcused absences or otherwise demonstrates a pattern of absenteeism during the school year, parents will be contacted and intervention steps shall be implemented by the school-based team, per Regulation 8140, to identify barriers and engage students in regular school attendance, per [8 VAC 20-730-20](#).

4. Nothing in this policy shall be construed to limit the authority of any attendance officer or the Superintendent or designee to seek immediate compliance with the compulsory school attendance law.

5. Referrals to an attendance officer will be made to address repeated unexcused absences or noncompliance with established interventions. An attendance officer may complete, sign, and file with the intake officer of the Loudoun County Juvenile and Domestic relations District Court pursuant to [22.1-258](#) of the Code of Virginia.

6. The attendance officer or the Superintendent or designee checks the reports submitted pursuant to subsection A of Va. Code § [22.1-260](#) with reports from the State Registrar of Vital Records and Health Statistics. From these reports and from any other reliable source the attendance officer or the Superintendent or designee, within five days after receiving all reports submitted pursuant to subsection A of Va. Code § [22.1-260](#), makes a list of the names of children who are not enrolled in any school and who are not exempt from school attendance. The attendance officer investigates all cases of non-enrollment and, when no valid reason is found therefor, notifies the parent/guardian or other person having control of the child to require the attendance of such child at the school within three days from the date of such notice.

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[Former Policy 8-17]

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Current Revision: 10/24/23

Leg Refs.: Virginia Code §§ [22.1-254](#); [22.1-258](#); [22.1-261](#); [22.1-207.7](#); [22.1-277.05](#); [22.1-277.2:1](#); [8 VAC 20-110-130](#); [8 VAC 20-730-10](#); [8 VAC 20-730-20](#)

Cross Refs.: [Policy 8120](#), Compulsory Attendance; Regulation [8140](#)